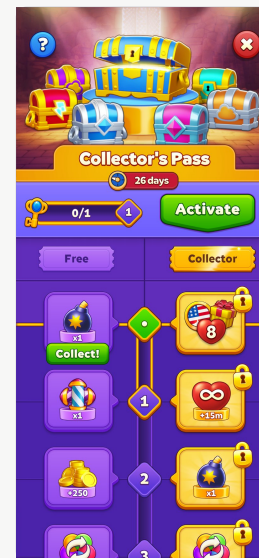
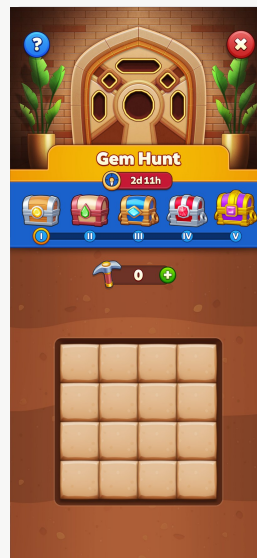
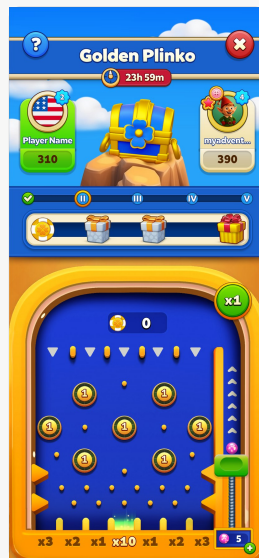


Diyana Lambova

Generalist Game Designer · Systems, Progression & LiveOps

Nine years in free-to-play mobile games, six of them in design, and more than twenty titles across my career. I'm a generalist: I design the systems players live inside — core loops, progression, live events, economy — and the way a feature feels to use.

This is a selection of features I designed end to end and shipped to live games. All screenshots are from publicly released builds.



SELECTED WORK · 2023 – 2026

How I work

WHAT I DESIGN

I'm a generalist game designer. I design systems, flows and the way features feel: mechanics, pacing, progression, balance, states and feedback. I write the specs, tune the numbers, build wireframes and mockups to communicate intent, and define the moments that need weight. I don't produce final game-ready assets — that's the UI artists, who I work alongside, together with engineering.

HOW A FEATURE USUALLY RUNS

Idea and framing, data and competitor research, spec and economy model, simulation and balance, build with engineering and art, QA and edge cases, soft launch or A/B test, then post-release monitoring and the next iteration. On Collect 'Em All I was the only designer, so every feature in this document ran through all of those stages with me.

WHAT I CARE ABOUT

That a player understands a feature without reading anything. That the balance holds before it ships rather than after. That the reward for staying is bigger than the reward for arriving. And that a feature which isn't working gets fixed or cut, not defended.

EXPERIENCE

Senior Game Designer, Tarboosh Games (Voodoo group) — sole designer on Collect 'Em All. On Color Clash my main remit was the cards: rebalancing and revamping existing ones, and designing new cards with new mechanics, alongside combat balance and the game's first live event.

DECA Games, 2017–2023 — DragonVale and other live titles. Promoted from Game Master to LiveOps Designer to Generalist Game Designer.

THE TWO GAMES IN THIS DOCUMENT

Collect 'Em All — casual puzzle. US-led audience, predominantly women aged 50+. Designing for this audience means no unexplained systems, no hidden depth and no friction between wanting something and getting it.

Color Clash — card strategy. Younger audience, predominantly men aged 18–24, competitive and fluent in game conventions. The same mechanic is designed very differently for each.

ALSO

Remote from Bulgaria (UTC+2). Comfortable in fast, small teams and in writing the documentation nobody else wants to write.

Golden Plinko

An arcade stake-and-drop event, built around scarcity rather than frequency.

THE PROBLEM

The LiveOps calendar was saturated. Events ran daily or weekly, and none of them felt like an occasion. I wanted a feature that created demand through scarcity rather than frequency, and that gave players something to do outside the core match loop.

THE DESIGN

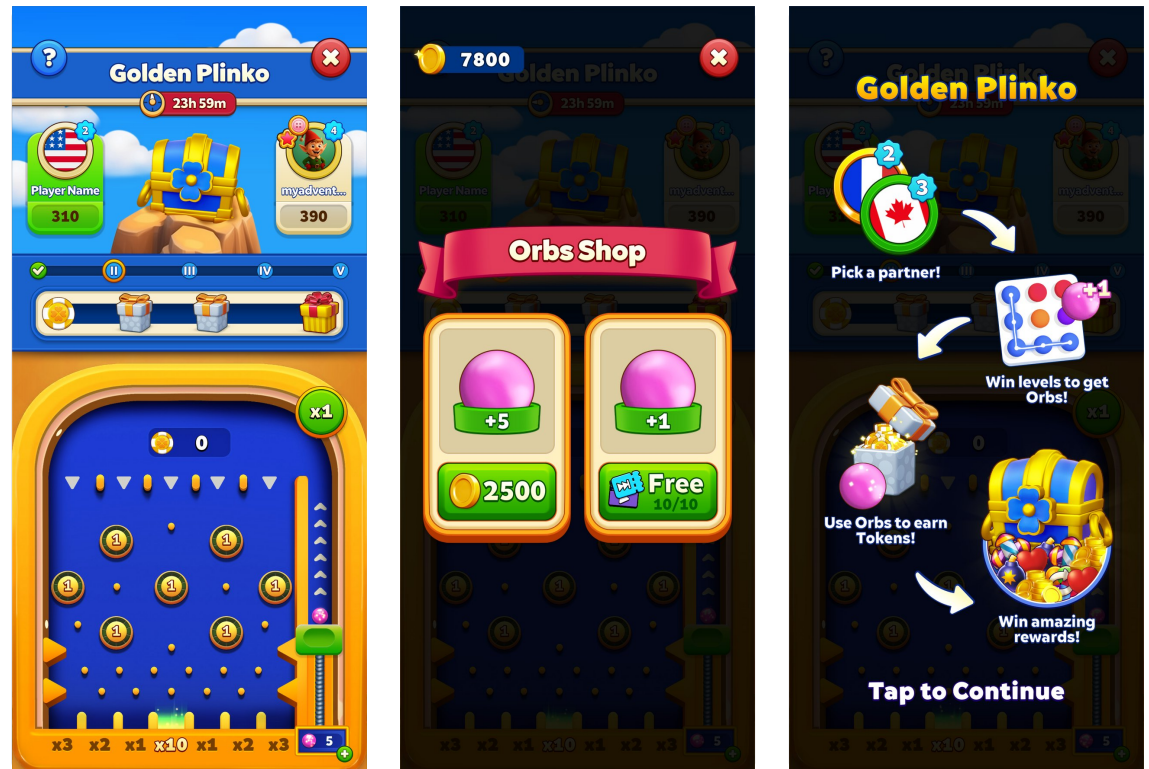
A five-day collaborative event running once a fortnight. The player picks a simulated partner and the two work toward a shared milestone track, so the event reads as co-operative without depending on a live player base. At its centre is a homage to arcade Plinko: players earn Orbs by winning levels, set a stake, drop, and watch. A higher stake multiplies the payout and the risk, which turns a passive animation into a decision with anticipation behind it.

WHAT I OWNED

Everything from the first idea to the production release: core gameplay and board elements, the stake system, partner progression curves, milestone and reward balance, cadence and duration, collaborator selection flow, onboarding and tutorial, widget placement and entry points, how the event hooked into the main game, start and end scenarios, edge cases, haptics and SFX, and monetization through rewarded video, IAP and coin exchange. Plus the spec, and the post-release data watch that decides what the next iteration changes.

HOW I VALIDATED IT

I ran thousands of simulations against the payout curve before anything reached engineering, then played the live build to confirm the balance held in practice. It became one of the game's best-performing live events.



Gem Hunt

Reveal-and-discover tension, with rooms that grow as the rewards do.

THE PROBLEM

We needed an event that rewarded sustained play across several days without leaning on the core match loop, at a point when the game was still searching for a visual theme of its own.

THE DESIGN

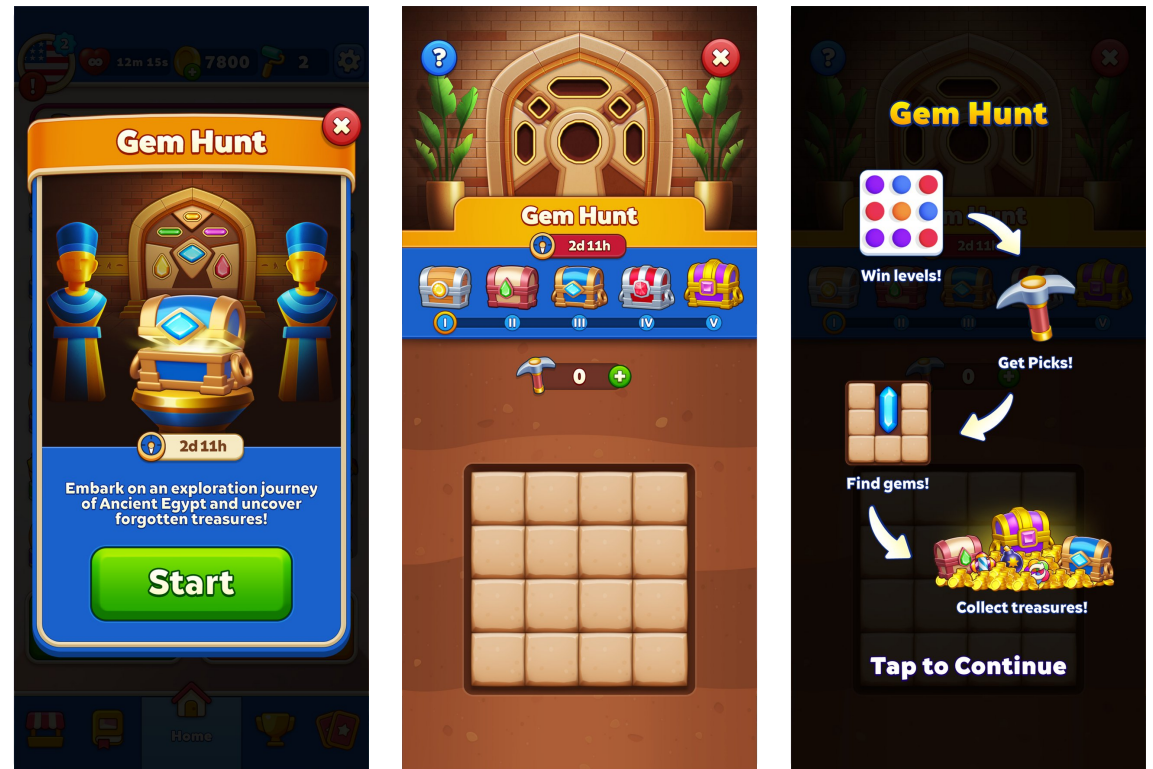
Players earn Picks by winning levels, then spend them to dig grid tiles and uncover gems. Find enough and the door opens, the treasure is claimed, and the next room begins. Each room raises the rewards and enlarges the grid, so tension and payoff scale together and the player always knows exactly what one more Pick is worth.

WHAT I OWNED

The digging flow, board elements, room progression and escalation curve, reward and milestone balance, cadence and duration, feature onboarding, widget placement, how the event connected to the core game, start and end scenarios, edge cases, haptics and SFX, and monetization through rewarded video, IAP and coin exchange.

WORKING PRACTICE

I tested the entire feature myself across states, rooms and edge cases before release, and it held up as one of the game's stronger recurring events.



Collector's Pass

A month-long track, and a payoff designed for the players who finish it early.

THE PROBLEM

The game had no long-form progression. Players had levels and nothing to work toward across a month, and nothing that marked them out as someone who had been here a while.

THE DESIGN

A monthly pass with parallel free and premium tracks, milestone rewards, locked stages and a claim flow built to be legible at a glance. Seasonal skins for Christmas, Halloween and Easter lifted adoption each time they ran.

COLLECTOR'S CHEST

Players who finished every tier before the month ended would otherwise stop earning. Instead, overflow pass currency collects in a chest and converts to coins at month end, claimable only by players who bought the pass. The track keeps paying after it is complete, and there is a reason to play through the tail of the month.

WHAT I OWNED

Track structure, reward and milestone balance, locked stage and claim flows, cadence and duration, visibility across multiple parts of the game, the cosmetic status layer — a golden frame and name visible to other players — and how widely it was distributed, so the status read as meaningful rather than universal. Plus edge cases, haptics and SFX.



Super Cannon

A win-streak booster, and the level re-balancing it forced.

CONTEXT

Collect 'Em All has two kinds of booster: ones players buy, and gameplay boosters earned inside a level by making specific links. Super Cannon is about the second kind — the ones a player triggers through play.

THE PROBLEM

The booster set had no high point, and players had little reason to spend on extra moves at the fail screen.

THE DESIGN

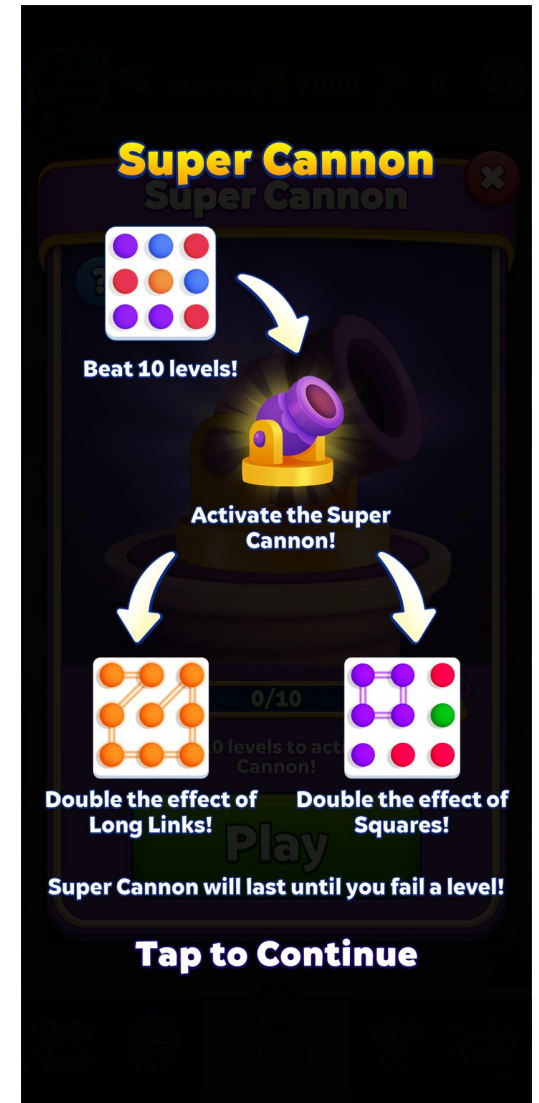
A supercharged booster that activates once a player has accumulated ten level wins — they don't need to be consecutive — and stays active until they lose a level. While it runs, it doubles the effect of the two core link mechanics, so the player feels unusually powerful — and arrives at the fail screen with something real to lose.

THE BALANCE PROBLEM IT CREATED

A booster that strong makes levels trivially easy, so I trimmed moves from the affected levels to keep the challenge honest and stop the feature distorting the coin economy. The point was never that players couldn't lose; it was that losing cost them something they had built.

WHAT I OWNED

Booster mechanic, activation and deactivation states, in-level visibility, unlock level, help item, the level re-balancing it required, widget placement, edge cases, haptics and SFX.



Daily Bonus

A streak worth protecting, and a forgiveness mechanic so it survives real life.

THE PROBLEM

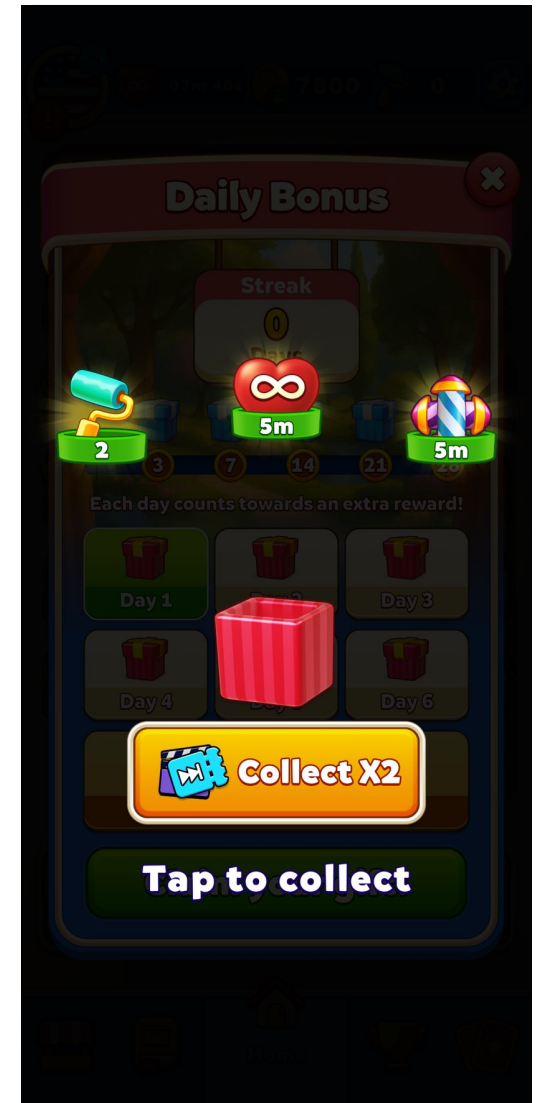
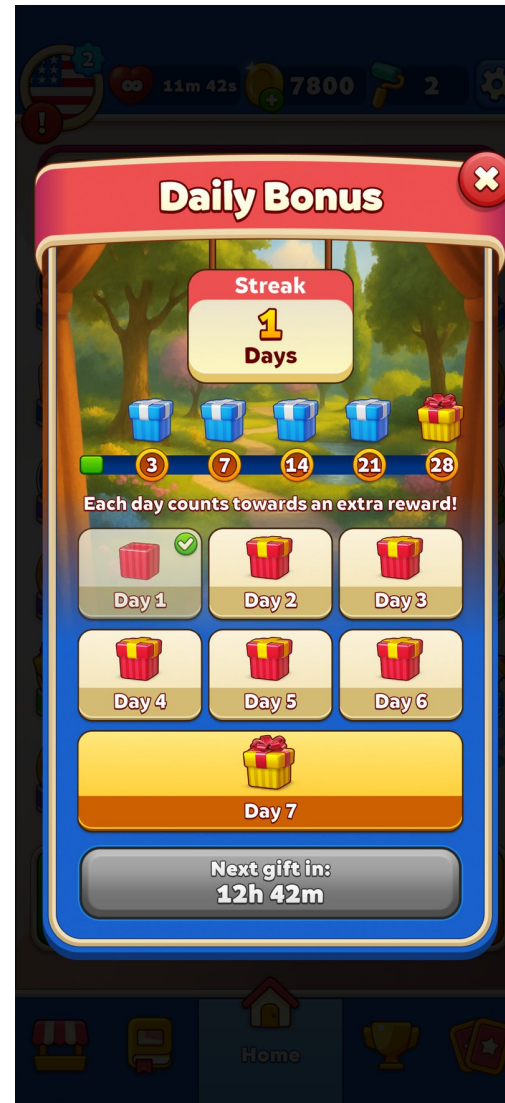
Churn. The game needed a reason to open the app on a day when nothing else was running, and a reason not to break the habit once it formed.

THE DESIGN

A daily login track on a seven-day cycle, with longer milestone rewards at 3, 7, 14, 21 and 28 days, and a save-streak mechanic so a single missed day doesn't erase weeks of progress. The streak counter is the real feature: what a player stands to lose grows the longer they keep it, which is what makes day sixty matter more than day three.

WHAT I OWNED

Reward balance, the save-streak cost and several balance iterations, milestone structure, widget placement, feature visibility, unlock level, help item, the doubled-reward video flow, edge cases, haptics and SFX.



Step Up

The game's first live event: async competition against a simulated field.

THE PROBLEM

Color Clash had no LiveOps at all. This was the first, and it had to work for a competitive audience of mostly 18–24 year old men without requiring a live opponent pool to be online at the same time.

THE DESIGN

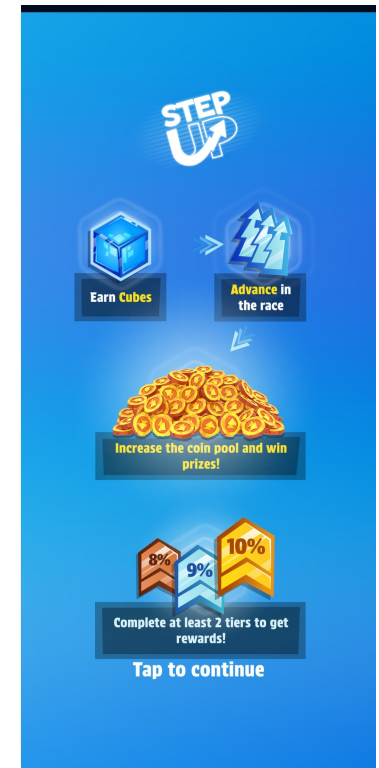
An asynchronous King of the Hill competition. Players advance linearly with each win, and every milestone completed adds coins to a shared pool, which is distributed by finishing rank when the event ends. The player competes against a simulated field, so the event delivers the feel of live competition without requiring an opponent pool to be online, and the shared pool means everyone's progress visibly raises the stakes.

WHAT I OWNED

Opponent progression curves, reward and milestone balance, pool allocation by rank, unlock conditions, feature visibility, help item, widget placement, edge cases, haptics and SFX.

NOTE ON CREDIT

Unlike Collect 'Em All, Color Clash had more than one designer — the studio's Creative Director also specced and designed features. My main remit on the game was the cards; Step Up was mine as well.



Electra

An epic stun card, designed to fill a strategic gap rather than a damage one.

MY REMIT ON COLOR CLASH

Most of my work on this game was the cards: rebalancing and revamping existing ones, and designing new cards that brought new mechanics into the roster. Electra is the one I'm proudest of.

THE OPPORTUNITY

A roster needs cards that change how a match is read, not just cards that hit harder. I was looking for a gap the existing cards didn't cover — a way to deny an opponent's push rather than out-damage it — and designed around that rather than around a stat line.

THE DESIGN

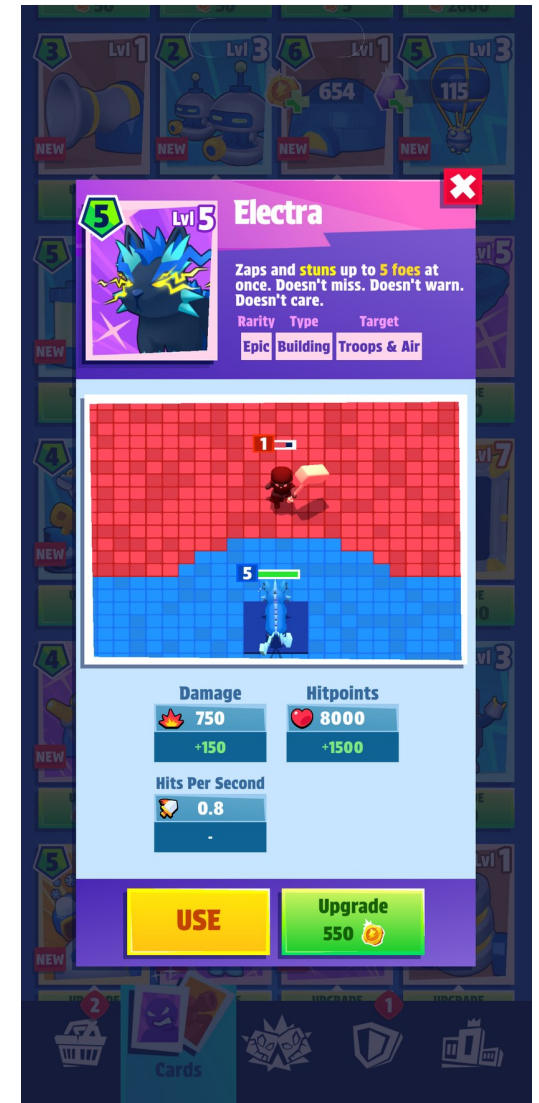
An epic building that zaps and stuns up to five targets at once, hitting troops and air. The stun is the point: it buys time and breaks timing, which gives players a defensive answer that rewards reading the board instead of reacting to it. I shaped the mechanic and the spec, evaluated where it sat against every other card, and defined not only the numbers but what it targeted, how it targeted, and how its special behaviour resolved in the edge cases.

WHAT I OWNED

Mechanic, spec and roster fit; stats balance, and the decision about which stats to surface to players and which to leave out; the card description and voice; the visual identity, which I sourced myself and which ended up defining the character; SFX and haptics. I then tested her personally against every other card in the game for interaction bugs.

OUTCOME

Electra added both personality and real strategic depth to the roster, and she found a settled place in it — played often enough to matter, never dominant enough to need a nerf.



Beyond the features in this document

ECONOMY & BALANCE

Economy modelling and sink/source balance, offer and pricing structures, currency ladders, reward curves and the simulation work behind them. I build the model before the feature exists, not after.

MONETIZATION

IAP catalogues and offer design, limited-time and chained offers, passes and subscriptions, rewarded video placement, and the shop structure around them. On Collect 'Em All, an onboarding and offer rebalance measurably improved conversion among new players, validated against a control group.

ONBOARDING & FTUE

Diagnosing where new players stall and fixing it. On Collect 'Em All, attempts-per-success was spiking on early levels and older players were quitting after a handful of retries — the game had tools that solved exactly that problem, but no tutorial for them and a two-step detour to reach them. Moving them into the main HUD and easing the early curve addressed frustration and conversion at the same time.

LEVELS & MECHANICS

Level design and level mechanics, difficulty curves and pacing, re-balancing live level sets when a new feature changes what players can do. Combat balance on a card strategy game.

TESTING & DATA

More than a hundred A/B tests across onboarding, difficulty, offers, features and UI. I'm as interested in the ones that failed: a large social feature the audience simply didn't want taught me to ask the demand question early and cheaply, which is now how I sequence every build.

RESEARCH & TOOLING

Competitor deconstruction and market research, including structured teardowns of hybrid-casual and ad-led titles. I build small internal tools with AI assistance when the team is losing time to something repeatable, and treat AI as a way to go faster, not a replacement for playing the game.

Diyana Lambova

Generalist Game Designer · Remote from Bulgaria (UTC+2)

di.lambova@gmail.com

linkedin.com/in/diyana-lambova-017895127